allowed to fight.

Finally, Akbar relented; and as he rode down the hill with his 200 men, his temper improved. When Man Singh asked to form a vanguard, Akbar agreed laughingly: ‘What force have we that we should make a division[?] Today we are all one.’[24]

What sort of battlefield did they have, for that matter? The ground leading to Sarnal was no great plain like Panipat’s, allowing for grand clashes of musket and sword. Rather, it was ‘broken ground’, littered with desert cacti.[25] The Mughal horses, wearing armour like their riders and trained to make daredevil charges upon the enemy, were forced, instead, to pick their way through the prickly pear with effete caution.

It was this infuriatingly slow advance, presumably, that gave Ibrahim time to prepare for the onslaught. The Mirza and his men littered Sarnal’s already narrow lanes with their baggage; this, along with a continuing abundance of cacti within, scattered Akbar’s men – not more than two could ride abreast. Riding through the clutter, with enemies around every corner, many of the Mughal troops died – including Bhagwant Das’s brother, ‘a very brave young man’[26] called Bhupat.

Akbar might have been reckless and short-tempered, but he wasn’t a coward. Having ordered his men into this shambolic onslaught, he led them from the front. With Bhagwant Das by his side, Akbar was riding a bay horse through the town’s narrow lanes, seeking Ibrahim, when three horsemen attacked – one the Rajput wounded with a well-aimed spear; the other two advanced on Akbar, who ‘received them so valiantly’, writes Badauni, ‘that they were obliged to make off’.

Surely, there was more than physical strength to this valour; something more than flattery in the ‘glory of the Divine radiance’ of which Abul Fazl writes, the force of which ‘affrighted’ Akbar’s opponents. He only had 200 men with him, after all, dispersed and distressed. Ibrahim had 1000. The battle was not of force alone, but of will: the Mirza did not continue a fight he might have won; he fled from Sarnal’s back gates. The Mughals chased after him until, as night fell ‘darker than . . . [his] fate’,[27] Akbar recalled his men and declared his triumph.

The rest of Akbar’s Gujarat campaign was relatively sedate, as if the fury of his chase after Ibrahim had given it enough momentum to coast on to